

Perspectives

Character & Grammar Through Stories

Episode 1 – The Recycling Debate

Level: B2–C1 (IELTS Band 6.5–8.0)

Student Name: _____

Date: _____

Level: B2–C1

Learning Goals

- ✓ Read and interpret a discursive, opinion-based story
- ✓ Recognise and use passive voice across a full range of tenses
- ✓ Use nominalisation to raise the formality of written English
- ✓ Acquire Academic Word List vocabulary and topic collocations
- ✓ Practise IELTS-style sentence transformation and error correction
- ✓ Produce an IELTS Task 2-style discursive paragraph
- ✓ Reflect critically on trade-offs, values, and differing perspectives

SECTION 1 | WARM-UP — Before You Read

Part A — Prediction & Opinion Questions

Instructions: These questions require you to take a position, not just guess a plot. Answer before reading.

1. To what extent do you agree that individuals — rather than governments or companies — bear the greatest responsibility for reducing waste?

2. Some people believe that small, local efforts (like one shop recycling) are meaningless without large-scale systems. To what extent do you agree?

Part B — Personal Reflection

Instructions: Answer honestly from your own experience or context.

1. Is waste separated or recycled in your household or neighbourhood? What makes this easy or difficult where you live?

2. Should small business owners be legally required to manage the waste they generate, or is this an unreasonable burden? Give a reason.

SECTION 2 | MAIN STORY — Read the Story

Instructions: Read the story carefully. Underline or highlight every passive-voice construction you notice, and circle any nominalised nouns (e.g. cooperation, contamination, agreement).

The Recycling Debate

Meherin had spent three years studying environmental science, but it was only during this term break that her research finally felt personal. For her final-year project, a community waste audit had been assigned to her, and she had chosen the market near her family's home in Sylhet as her site — mostly because her uncle, Momtaz Mia, ran a small grocery shop there, and she assumed his cooperation could be taken for granted.

She was wrong.

“You want me to keep three separate bins?” Momtaz Mia asked, wiping his hands on his lungi. “One for plastic, one for paper, one for... what did you call it? Organic waste?” He laughed, not unkindly. “Meherin, this shop has been run by our family for twenty years. Customers throw their wrappers wherever there's space. That habit will not be changed by three bins.”

“It won't be changed overnight,” Meherin admitted, “but habits are shaped by systems, Uncle. If nothing is provided, nothing will be sorted. If the option is given, at least some customers will use it.”

Momtaz Mia was not convinced. “And who collects it afterwards? The municipal truck comes once a week, and everything — plastic, paper, vegetable peels — is thrown into the same container by the same workers. Your three bins will be emptied into one van. What was the point of the separation?”

This was, Meherin knew, a fair criticism — one that had already been raised by her supervisor, in fact. The absence of a citywide segregation system was a real limitation, and no amount of enthusiasm on her part could be substituted for infrastructure that did not yet exist. But she had also read enough case studies to know that behavioural change was rarely initiated by governments alone; it was often driven, at least at first, by small, visible, local efforts.

“You're right that the system isn't ready,” she said. “But the data has to come from somewhere. If a pilot isn't tried by someone, the argument for a proper system will never be made convincingly to the city corporation. I'm not asking you to solve waste management in Sylhet. I'm asking for six weeks and three bins.”

Her uncle folded his arms. Behind him, a customer was being handed change, and a plastic packet of biscuits was being dropped, without a second thought, straight onto the floor beside the counter. Meherin gestured toward it. “That's what I mean,” she said quietly.

Momtaz Mia was silent for a moment. Then he said, “Six weeks. And if my sales are affected — if customers are annoyed by being asked to sort their own rubbish — the bins are removed, and we don't discuss it again.”

It was not the enthusiastic agreement Meherin had hoped for, but it was, she reminded herself, still an agreement. Over the following days, three labelled bins were placed near the shop entrance, a small hand-painted sign was put up by her cousin, and a simple log was kept of what was discarded and where.

The results, when they came, were not dramatic. Most customers ignored the bins entirely. A few, mostly younger ones, made a visible effort to use them correctly. Contamination — plastic wrappers found in the “organic” bin, vegetable peels found in the “paper” bin — was common. Whether this counted as failure or as a modest, realistic beginning was, Meherin realised, a matter of perspective rather than fact.

On the final evening of her project, she sat with her uncle as he closed the shop. “So,” he said, “was I right?”

“Partly,” Meherin said. “The habits weren't changed as fast as I'd hoped. But something was noticed by people who never would have noticed it before. I don't know if that's enough. Maybe it isn't.”

Momtaz Mia considered this for a long moment. “Keep the bins,” he said finally. “Not because I believe in your three-bin theory. Because you asked properly, and you didn't pretend it was simple.” He shrugged. “That's something, isn't it?”

Meherin wasn't sure if it was a victory. But she wrote it down anyway.

SECTION 3 | VOCABULARY ZONE

Instructions: Study the words and collocations below. They are drawn from the Academic Word List and the theme of environment and sustainability.

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
audit	noun	an official check or examination of something	নিরীক্ষা
segregation	noun	the act of separating things into groups	পৃথকীকরণ
cooperation	noun	working together with someone	সহযোগিতা
contamination	noun	the state of being made impure by mixing with something unwanted	দূষণ / মিশ্রণজনিত অশুদ্ধতা
infrastructure	noun	the basic systems and structures a place needs to function	অবকাঠামো
pilot (project)	noun/adj.	a small trial version tested before a full launch	পরীক্ষামূলক (প্রকল্প)
initiative	noun	a new plan or action taken to solve a problem	উদ্যোগ
skeptical	adjective	doubtful; not easily convinced	সন্দেহপ্রবণ
sustainable	adjective	able to continue over time without causing long-term harm	টেকসই
municipal	adjective	relating to a town or city's local government	পৌর
criticism	noun	a comment pointing out faults or problems	সমালোচনা
discard	verb	to throw something away because it is not needed	ফেলে দেওয়া
visible	adjective	able to be seen or noticed	দৃশ্যমান

Word / Phrase	Part of Speech	Simple English Meaning	বাংলা অর্থ
contamination-free	adjective	not mixed with unwanted or harmful material	দূষণমুক্ত
take (something) for granted	phrase	to assume something is certain, without checking	কিছু স্বতঃসিদ্ধ ধরে নেওয়া
a drop in the ocean	phrase	an effort too small to make a real difference	সমুদ্রে এক ফোঁটা (নগণ্য প্রচেষ্টা)
in the long run	phrase	eventually; over a long period of time	দীর্ঘমেয়াদে

Task A — Matching

Instructions: Match each word with its correct meaning. Write the letter in the Your Answer column.

Word	Your Answer
1. contamination	_____
2. infrastructure	_____
3. skeptical	_____
4. initiative	_____
5. segregation	_____
6. criticism	_____

- A. a new plan or action to solve a problem
- B. doubtful; not easily convinced
- C. the basic systems a place needs to function
- D. a comment pointing out faults
- E. the act of separating into groups
- F. the state of being made impure by mixing

Task B — Fill in the Blanks

Instructions: Choose the best word from the box and complete the sentences.

Word Box: audit | municipal | sustainable | discard | pilot

- Meherin's final-year project required her to conduct a waste _____ of a local market.
- According to Momtaz Mia, the _____ truck collects everything in a single container anyway.
- Meherin argued that small local efforts can eventually support a more _____ system of waste management.
- Customers were used to _____ their wrappers wherever there was space.
- Meherin asked her uncle for six weeks to run a small _____ project.

Task C — Vocabulary in Context

Instructions: Read each quotation from the story and guess the meaning of the underlined word from context.

- "The absence of a citywide segregation system was a real limitation." What does limitation mean here?

2. “No amount of enthusiasm could be substituted for infrastructure that did not yet exist.” What does substituted mean here?

3. “Behavioural change was rarely initiated by governments alone.” What does initiated mean here?

4. “Contamination... was common.” What does contamination mean in this context?

5. “It was, she reminded herself, still an agreement.” What does agreement mean here?

SECTION 4 | GRAMMAR DETECTIVE 🔍 — Passive Voice & Nominalisation

Task A — Find from the Story

Instructions: Find and copy the required number of examples for each grammar focus from the story.

Grammar Focus	Examples from the Story
2 Present Simple Passive	
2 Past Simple Passive	
1 Past Continuous Passive	
1 Past Perfect Passive	
1 Future Passive	
2 Passive of Modals (can/will/could + be + V3)	
3 Nominalisations (verb/adjective → noun)	

Task B — Grammar Lab

Instructions: For each sentence, identify the structure, explain why it is used, and write a similar sentence of your own.

1. "This shop has been run by our family for twenty years."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used (instead of active voice / a verb phrase)? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

2. "Everything is thrown into the same container by the same workers."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used (instead of active voice / a verb phrase)? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

3. "A customer was being handed change."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used (instead of active voice / a verb phrase)? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

4. "The absence of a citywide segregation system was a real limitation."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used (instead of active voice / a verb phrase)? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

5. "The argument for a proper system will never be made convincingly."

Which grammar structure is used? _____

Why is it used (instead of active voice / a verb phrase)? _____

Write a similar sentence: _____

SECTION 5 | MIXED GRAMMAR CHALLENGE

A — Error Correction

Instructions: Each sentence contains one passive-voice error. Rewrite it correctly.

1. The bins was placed near the shop entrance by her cousin.

2. A community waste audit have been assigned to her.

3. The truck will emptied the bins into one van.

4. Momtaz Mia's shop is run by his family since twenty years.

5. The decision were made after a long discussion.

B — Multiple Choice

Instructions: Choose the best answer: A, B, C, or D.

1. The shop _____ by Momtaz Mia's family for twenty years.
A. is run B. has been run C. was run D. runs Answer: _____

2. Everything _____ into the same container every week.
A. throws B. is thrown C. was throwing D. has thrown Answer: _____

3. When Meherin arrived, a customer _____ change at the counter.
A. was being handed B. is handed C. handed D. has handed Answer: _____

4. The three bins _____ near the entrance last week.
A. place B. were placed C. are placing D. has placed Answer: _____

5. If the pilot succeeds, a full system _____ eventually.
A. will be introduced B. introduces C. introduced D. is introducing Answer: _____

C — Gap Fill

Instructions: Complete each sentence with the correct passive form of the verb in brackets.

1. The waste audit _____ (assign) to Meherin at the start of the term.

2. Three labelled bins _____ (place) near the shop entrance last week.

3. At that moment, a plastic packet _____ (drop) onto the floor by a customer.

4. The final decision _____ (not / make) until the six weeks were over.

5. If the results are positive, a larger project _____ (consider) next year.

D — Sentence Transformation

Instructions: Rewrite each sentence as directed. Keep the meaning the same.

1. **Original:** Someone had already raised this criticism.

Change to Passive Voice:

This criticism _____.

2. **Original:** The city corporation must implement proper recycling systems.

Change to Passive Voice (with modal):

Proper recycling systems _____.

3. **Original:** Meherin's uncle finally agreed to cooperate.

Change the verb 'cooperate' to a noun (nominalisation) and rewrite:

Meherin's uncle finally agreed to give his _____.

SECTION 6 | SENTENCE BUILDER — Build Your Own Sentences

Instructions: Use each word or phrase to write one original sentence, following the required grammar structure exactly. Do not copy from the story.

Word / Phrase	Required Grammar Structure	Your Sentence
segregation	Passive voice, present simple	
cooperation	Nominalisation (turn 'cooperate' into a noun in your sentence)	
skeptical	Passive voice, past simple	
infrastructure	Passive voice, modal (should be / must be)	
in the long run	Passive voice, future simple	

SECTION 7 | SHORT WRITING TASK — Think & Write

Instructions: Write 150–180 words. Use at least three examples of passive voice and two nominalised nouns. Write down the main paragraphs only.

Prompt:

Some people believe that responsibility for reducing waste lies mainly with individuals and small businesses. Others believe that governments and municipal authorities should be responsible for providing the infrastructure needed for recycling. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Writing Space

SECTION 8 | CHARACTER REFLECTION — Character Corner

Instructions: These questions have no single correct answer. Discuss with a partner if possible, then write your own considered response.

1. Momtaz Mia agreed to the trial not because he was convinced by the argument, but because Meherin “asked properly” and “didn’t pretend it was simple.” What does this suggest about how change is actually negotiated between generations, as opposed to how it is argued for in theory?

2. To what extent should young people push their elders toward new practices (environmental or otherwise), and to what extent should they accept established, existing ways of doing things?

3. The story ends without a clear resolution — the bins remain, but neither character is fully proven right. Why might a story without a tidy conclusion be more honest than one with a clear moral lesson?

4. Is a “modest, realistic beginning” enough to justify the effort involved, or is meaningful change only meaningful when it happens at scale?

SECTION 9 | HOMEWORK

Level 1	Level 2
Write 6 sentences about recycling or waste management, each using the passive voice in a different tense (present, past, future, modal, continuous, perfect).	Write a reflective diary/essay entry (150–180 words) titled “A Time I Tried to Change Someone's Mind.” Use at least 3 passive constructions and 2 nominalised nouns.

Final Reminder: *Precise grammar is what allows a nuanced argument to be expressed clearly. In the long run, the quality of your reasoning is judged by the clarity of your language.*